BC phenom Mara ‘one in a million’ as a dual-sport D1 athlete

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ProQuest document link

FULL TEXT

In November 2025, more than a dozen coaches, athletic trainers, nutritionists, and medical professionals gathered in a conference room in Chestnut Hill to answer one question:

What do we do about Emily Mara?

Only 1 percent of the approximately 200,000 athletes in NCAA Division 1 compete in multiple sports. Mara, a sophomore at Boston College, is the only athlete competing in both women’s soccer and hockey.

The Winchester native’s unusual physical talent, combined with seemingly boundless energy and a cerebral approach to her sports, makes her uniquely positioned to do what many told her was impossible, her coaches explained.

“Her body can take it. Her psyche can take it, too, with all the ups and downs, and her shoulders can take it with the load she bears mentally,’’ BC women’s soccer coach Chris Watkins said. “She’s one in a million.’’

Increasingly, the landscape works against athletes like Mara.

Single-sport specialization begins at an earlier and earlier age, pushed by parents and coaches, but also young athletes themselves. And soccer and hockey are among the most time-consuming and financially demanding sports — particularly at the club level.

But Mara excelled in both at Phillips Academy, Andover, and went through the recruiting process for both soccer and hockey.

Some schools flat-out rejected the idea that Mara could play both at the Division 1 level. Either they wanted her undivided attention or they were worried about injury risk, or both.

BC was the exception. Watkins and women’s hockey coach Katie Crowley wanted her on board no matter what.

“They were probably two of the most supportive coaches I’ve ever spoken to,’’ Mara said.

There weren’t many options for Mara to play at the highest level, either. Just 45 schools sponsor Division 1 women’s hockey programs, and most don’t have a high-level women’s soccer program. BC soccer plays in the ACC, the most competitive conference in the NCAA. On the ice, the Eagles are a perennial contender in Hockey East.

If it were up to her, Mara would attend every minute of every practice and play every game for both. But there was one caveat demanded by Watkins: Since Mara’s education was paid for by a soccer scholarship, that team would have to be her priority.

A forward, Mara is in the thick of soccer season, where she has four goals and seven assists for the 9-2-1 Eagles. She will practice exclusively with the soccer team through the end of its season in early November, then shift gears to hockey once the postseason wraps up.

“She was lobbying all of us, saying she doesn’t need a day off,’’ Watkins said, recalling the meeting last fall. “She just wants to go, and we’re trying to get her to slow down.’’

Last year, her soccer season ended Oct. 30, and Mara spent the next seven days studying film and skating as much as she could. She had already missed the first 10 games of the hockey season and would be damned if she missed another.

Mara made her college hockey debut Nov. 7, on less than a week of practice.

“I just don’t know if I could picture what I would do with an offseason,’’ said Mara, who this summer played for USL W League team Vermont Green FC. “Like, I’d have too much free time.’’

Mara committed to BC as a soccer player but had been in talks with the hockey staff throughout the recruiting process. In

the summer before her freshman year, the team still had open roster spots, so Crowley figured she'd give Mara a shot.
"What Emily brings to the team, it outweighs the fact that she's not here for the first month and a half,'' Crowley said. "Her energy, the kind of person she is — it's worth it to have a player like her.''
Adding a player to the lineup partway through the season could be a recipe for intrasquad tension, and Crowley had a few conversations early last fall to preemptively smooth things over.
If Mara's hockey teammates had any qualms about her late arrival, however, they never showed it. Mara was a welcome addition to the room, Crowley said, and she went on to record three assists in 25 games.
"You have to be someone that your teammates really like being around, right?'' Crowley said. "Because you're coming in after a month or month and a half of the season, and maybe getting in the lineup over somebody, and sometimes those things can be a little bit tricky.''
This year, the soccer regular season wraps on Nov. 5. The hockey team again will already have played 10 games.
Hockey and soccer require different muscle groups — running puts more pressure on your shins and knees compared to skating, which is tougher on the hips — so overuse injuries aren't a huge concern for Mara or her coaches.
The way Mara sees it, she's just as likely to get injured playing one sport year round than she is playing two sports and splitting her time. If anything, cross-training is beneficial to her long-term health.
Her coaches tend to agree, though Watkins noted Mara covers more distance on average in a soccer game than any other athlete on the team, and because of her small frame, she often takes a beating from opponents.
"Even if she didn't play another sport, there's a lot of risk,'' he said. "But she's a unicorn.''
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Credit: Emma Healy Globe Staff

DETAILS

Subject:	Athletic recruitment; Coaches & managers; Soccer; Hockey
Company / organization:	Name: National Collegiate Athletic Association--NCAA; NAICS: 813990
Publication title:	Boston Globe; Boston, Mass.
First page:	C.1
Publication year:	2026
Publication date:	Oct 8, 2026
Section:	Sports
Publisher:	Boston Globe Media Partners, LLC
Place of publication:	Boston, Mass.
Country of publication:	United States
Publication subject:	General Interest Periodicals--United States
ISSN:	07431791
Source type:	Newspaper

Language of publication:	English
Document type:	News
ProQuest document ID:	3396887614
Document URL:	https://login.ezproxy.uvm.edu/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/newspapers/bc-phenom-mara-one-million-as-dual-sport-d1/docview/3396887614/se-2?accountid=14679
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Last updated:	2026-10-08
Database:	ProQuest Central Premium

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